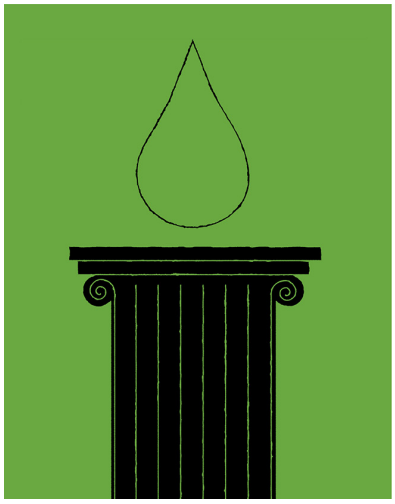


WATER IS A PUBLIC TRUST, AND A HUMAN RIGHT

THE WATER CRISIS

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Maude Barlow (1947–)

BEFORE

1983–5 Droughts in Ethiopia, Eritrea, and Sudan cause 450,000 deaths.

1990 The desiccation of the Aral Sea is declared the world's worst ecological disaster of the 20th century by the UN Environment Programme.

2008 The United Nations estimates that around 42,000 people die every week from diseases related to bad water and poor sanitation.

AFTER

2012–16 California suffers one of its worst droughts on record. It impacts agriculture, nature, and daily life.

2017 Water campaigner Maude Barlow reveals that half of China's rivers have disappeared since 1990.

In 2008, Canadian activist Maude Barlow argued that water shortage had become the most pressing ecological and human crisis of the 21st century. Stressing that water is a "Commons" (a shared resource) and that access to